BOOKS

CARVING A NEW NICHE

Indian publishers are betting big on vernacular books translated into English for a larger audience



CREATING HISTORY Geetanjali Shree, who won the Booker Prize for her Hindi novel *Ret Samadhi/ Tomb of Sand*

GETTY IMAGES

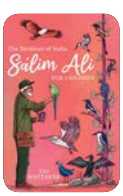
LAST YEAR, AFTER GEETANJALI SHREE'S Hindi novel *Ret Samadhi/Tomb of Sand* (translated into English by Daisy Rockwell) won the International Booker Prize, my inbox was abuzz with messages from American acquaintances and some fellow writers. Who's this incredible Indian writer and why are we hearing about her only now, they wanted to know. That apart, there has been a general surge of interest in books translated from the Indian languages and the momentum has been building for a few years. In 2017, Vivek Shanbhag's novella *Ghachar Ghochar* (translated into English by Srinath Perur) received rave reviews across America and ended up on *The New York Times*' end-of-the-year Notable Books list. The year 2020 saw Tamil writer Perumal Murugan's novel *Poonachi* (translated into English by N. Kalyan Raman) being nominated for a National Book Award for Translated Literature, one of the most prestigious American literary prizes. Earlier this year, Murugan was also on the International Booker longlist for his novel *Pyre* (translated into English by Aniruddhan Vasudevan).

In the domestic market, too, translated literature is seeing success. Publishers are placing more bets on translations and are looking to build a library of translated Indian literature from across the country. Earlier, Bangla or Malayalam dominated the translated literature shelf, but now, certain languages that saw little to no representation are coming to the fore.

Speaking as a Bihari person, I was happy to see a Bhojpuri novel translated into English (Kapil Pandey's *Phoolsunghi*, translated by Gautam Choubey) in 2020 and Harimohan Jha's Maithili novel *Kanyadaan* being translated into English (by Lalit Kumar) as *The Bride* in 2022. During an interview, Minakshi Thakur, who is in charge of Westland's translations-focused 'Eka' imprint and has previously worked with HarperCollins India on their translation imprint (Harper Perennials), spoke about the enhanced landscape for translations. "There has been a

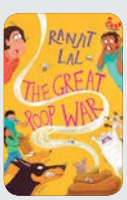
NATURE LIBRARY

*A small herd of **children's books** focused on animals and the natural world in India*



THE BIRDMAN OF INDIA: Salim Ali for Children
by Zai Whitaker; illustrations by Rohan Dahotre
HACHETTE INDIA
₹350; 152 pages

This engaging mini-biography of the pioneering Indian ornithologist is written by his grand-niece. While recounting Ali's adventures, Whitaker loses no opportunity in introducing children to a spot of natural history. For example, an account of field work in Kerala leads to a discussion on why the region's wildlife signature is similar to those associated with "the Eastern Himalayas, Western China, Burma and even Malaysia".



THE GREAT POOP WAR
by Ranjit Lal; illustrations by Ambika Karandikar
RED PANDA/WESTLAND BOOKS; **₹275; 135** pages

Set amidst Delhi's RWAs (Residents' Welfare Associations) and pet-owners frequently at odds with them, *The Great Poop War* by Ranjit Lal is a rambunctious comedy. RWA president Gangajal Badrinath of Sparkling Apartments has declared war on the pet dogs and cats in his vicinity. The aim: to unmask a serial pooper stinking up the place. Bharat and Parvati, best friends and animal lovers, must solve the mystery.